Songs of Ourselves Volume 1, Part 4

Exam code: 0475 & 0992

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Songs of Ourselves Volume 1, Part 4 Anthology Overview

For Paper 1, Section A of your CIE IGCSE Literature in English, you will study a cluster of 15 poems in the Songs of Ourselves Volume 1, Part 4 anthology cluster.

This page includes:

- A complete list of the poems in the cluster
- A brief overview of what is required in the exam
- A brief explanation of some of the key themes
- Top tips for the highest grade

Songs of Ourselves, Volume 1, Part 4 poems

Here is a list of all the poems in the Songs of Ourselves, Vol.1, part 4 cluster:

Title	Poet
'The City Planners'	Margaret Atwood
'The Planners'	Boey Kim Cheng
'The Man with Night Sweats'	Thom Gunn
'Night Sweat'	Robert Lowell
'Rain'	Edward Thomas
'The Spirit is too Blunt an Instrument'	Anne Stevenson
'From Long Distance'	Tony Harrison
'Funeral Blues'	W.H. Auden
'He Never Expected Much'	Thomas Hardy

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Got it

'A Consumer's Report'	Peter Porter
'Request to a Year'	Judith Wright
'On Finding a Small Fly Crushed in a Book'	Charles Tennyson Turner
'Ozymandias'	Percy Bysshe Shelly
'Away, Melancholy'	Stevie Smith

Help me understand

Overview

In Paper 1, Section A, you will be given a choice of two poetry exam questions. Each question will be based on one of the 15 poems in your anthology and a copy of the poem printed in full will be provided for each of the questions. You only have to answer **one** of these two questions. It is really important that you read through the exam instructions carefully, and make sure you have selected the correct question and poem according to the cluster of poems you have studied.

Examiner Tips and Tricks

To write a successful response, you need to sustain a clear focus on the key words of the question. Make sure you select relevant quotations and craft your answer so it meets the demands of the question.

Having a detailed knowledge of a poem is one of the things you need to display in order to achieve the highest marks. However, make sure you don't waste time writing everything you know about the poem as your response will sound too general and have no real focus. The aim is to make sure you respond to the key words in the question, and if you do that well, you are on your way to success!

This question will be in Section A of Paper 1 and is worth 25 marks, so you should aim to spend between 40–45 minutes on it in the exam. In order to write a top-grade response, you should aim to write a brief introduction, at least three paragraphs and a brief conclusion. Make sure you focus on the key words in the question and remember that you will have a copy of the poem in the exam. However, it is crucial that you revise and have a thorough understanding of each poem in order to use the time in your exam effectively: relying on having the poem printed out for you will significantly slow you down.

Below you will find a summary of some of the key themes in the anthology. To find out how each of these themes is explored in the anthology poems, please read the individual revision pages for detailed and specific analysis.

Mortality and grief

Mortality and grief is a theme that can be found in some of the poems in the anthology. It includes:

- The realisation that death is imminent and inevitable, as is evident in the poem 'Rain'
- The grief that naturally occurs when a loved one passes away, which can be seen in Auden's 'Funeral Blues'
- The fear of dying without leaving a **legacy** behind, which is a key theme in 'On Finding a Small Fly Crushed in a Book'
- The different **manifestations** of grief when a loved one passes away, which can be seen in 'Long Distance Call'

Nature versus civilisation

The theme of nature versus civilisation is explored in various ways in some of the poems in the anthology, including:

- The conflict between the need for suburban neighbourhoods and the struggle to overpower nature, which can be seen in 'The City Planners'
- The loss of beauty and inspiration due to humanity's desire for modernisation, as is evident in the poem 'The Planners'
- The heartless and clinical methods that humanity has used to overpower and destroy nature, which can also be found in the poem 'The Planners'
- The power of nature and nature's ability to outlive other forms of power can be seen in 'Ozymandias'

Human power

The idea of human power is explored in some of the poems in the anthology. Some examples of this are:

- 'Ozymandias' was written as a commentary on the futile nature of human power
- Humanity's attempt at manipulating and controlling nature can be seen in the poem 'The Planners'
- 'Away, Melancholy' is a poem that questions the power of God and whether human beings have created the idea of God, instead of believing in their own power and strength

Examiner Tips and Tricks

It is important to note that the most convincing responses **sustain** a **critical analysis** of the ways in which writers achieve their effects. Make sure you embed evidence that is well-selected and relevant to the key words in the question.

It is not enough, for example, to say that the writer uses an ABAB rhyme scheme without analysing specific examples from the text and showing how the writer has used it to

to reinforce the writer's overarching message or theme.

Top tips for the highest grade

- Referring to a writer's methods or linguistic terminology without linking it to a theme will not get you marks:
  - Writer's methods and the analysis of language, form and structure should always be based on the theme given to you in your question
- For example, writing "Adcock writes the poem in free verse" will not get you a mark:
  - However, writing "Adcock writes the poem in free verse to mirror the conversational style of a phone call to give the poem an element of realism" will
- Including historical facts or biographical information about the poet does not add value to your answers:
  - If you are addressing the focus of the question, then you are addressing context
- If you know the poems well, you will be able to demonstrate this knowledge and understanding in the exam:
  - Learning the poems and their themes and ideas, rather than learning lists of quotes, will benefit you greatly
  - Don't just rely on having the poem printed on the exam paper
- Make sure you read the question and highlight the focus:
  - Then read the poem to find evidence that links to the focus in the question
- You don't get extra marks for more quotations, but you do get more marks for making plenty of interesting comments about the quotes you have selected:
  - Zoom in on words and phrases from the quote that you can analyse and link back to the focus of the question
- Make sure you show personal engagement with the texts while focusing directly on the key words in the question and avoid making general comments:
  - If the question has used words such as "powerful", "vivid" and "memorable" for example, they want you to engage with the text by making insightful comments
- Try not to be literal in your responses:
  - Instead of commenting on what a word means, try to think about how the word presents a character or a theme:
    - For example, "the use of the phrase 'firmness of her hand' could symbolise the speaker's desire for her great-great-grandmother's artistic skill, but could also suggest that she longs for the

a conscious construct, and will keep reminding you that the poet deliberately put the poem together
- Use connectives to link your ideas and analysis and to make sure your analysis is structured

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